

Visual Hierarchy

Visual hierarchy is the arrangement of design elements in order of importance. By establishing hierarchy you control how the user scans a page and what they notice first.

Size is the most powerful tool for hierarchy. Larger elements attract attention before smaller ones. Use at most two or three distinct sizes on a single screen to avoid competing focal points.

Color and contrast also create hierarchy. A bright accent on a muted background draws the eye. Reserve the strongest contrast for the most important action on the page.

Position matters: users read from top-left to bottom-right in Western layouts. Place the primary call to action where the eye naturally lands first.

Whitespace creates hierarchy by giving important elements breathing room. An isolated element reads as more important than one crowded by neighbors.

Typography

Typography is the craft of arranging type to make language legible, readable, and appealing. Good type systems use a small set of typefaces with clear roles: headings, body, and captions.

Line length between 45 and 75 characters is most comfortable for body text. Line height of 1.5 for body copy improves readability on screens.

Font size should be at least 16 pixels for body text on mobile interfaces to reduce eye strain.

Color

A limited color palette improves cohesion. Start with one neutral, one primary, and one accent color, then add semantic colors for success, warning, and error states.

Ensure text meets contrast ratios of at least 4.5:1 for normal text and 3:1 for large text to satisfy WCAG accessibility guidelines.

Feedback and States

Every interactive element needs clear states: hover, pressed, focused, disabled, and loading. Consistent feedback reduces user errors and builds confidence.

Loading states should appear within 100 milliseconds of an action. If a task takes longer than one second, show a progress indicator or skeleton screen.

Navigation

Navigation should answer three questions at all times: where am I, where can I go, and how do I get back. Visible, predictable navigation reduces cognitive load.